

Tritheism Denial

doc-tritheism-denial

Theology Proper · Trinity · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.900
confidence high

Statement under examination

The three Persons of the Trinity share one divine essence; they are not three separate gods.

In plain language

The Hebrew Bible repeatedly says God is one, but the word one is not the whole argument. Deuteronomy 6:4 puts YHWH together with the cardinal number one in predicate position, YHWH our God is one. Yet the same Hebrew word for one also describes a husband and wife becoming one flesh in Genesis 2:24 and a crowd acting as one people in Genesis 11:6, so by itself the number one can describe a unity that still contains more than one part. The real force against three gods comes from the exclusivity words. Isaiah 45:5 stacks several small particles meaning no, none, no other, besides me. Isaiah 44:6 adds first and last and besides me there is no god, using a second rare word for besides. Deuteronomy 4:35 repeats no other besides him. These words flatly deny that any other god exists alongside YHWH, which is exactly what rules out three separate gods. The New Testament keeps this count. In Mark 12:29 Jesus quotes the Shema and uses the Greek numeral one of God, and in 1 Corinthians 8:4 Paul writes there is no God except one. Then in 1 Corinthians 8:6 Paul takes that one confession and names one God the Father and one Lord Jesus Christ inside it, with the words from whom and through whom mapping creation to both. He does not produce two gods. He places Father and Son within the single deity. Matthew 28:19 keeps the same balance, using a singular word name over three distinct named Persons, which blocks both three gods and a collapse into one Person. The seam that lets readers diverge is the numeral one, since it can mean either a bare single unit or a composite unity. The exclusivity particles settle the question against three gods, while the distinct named Persons inside the one confession keep the persons from being erased. The lexical pattern supports the proposition that the three Persons are one God and not three separate gods.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0259	אֶחָד	echad	one	944
H0314	אֲחֵרֹן	acharon	last	
H0369	אֵין	ayin	nothing	720
H0430	אֱלֹהִים	elohim	God	2,602
H0589	אֲנִי	ani	I	
H0905	בַּד	bad	alone	
H1107	בְּלִעְדִּי	biladey	beside	16
H2108	זוּלָּה	zulah	exception	13
H3045	יָדַע	yada	to know	
H3068	יְהוָה	YHWH	LORD	6,828

H3808	לֹא	lo	not	4,825
H5750	עוד	od	still	456
G0235	ἀλλά	alla	but	
G1223	διὰ	dia	through/because of	
G1519	εἰς	eis	toward	
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	367
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2962	κύριος	kurios	lord	
G3762	οὐδείς	oudeis	none	
G3962	πατήρ	pater	father	426
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	581

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The canon predicates the cardinal numeral one of God directly, **אֶחָד** in the Shema (Deut 6:4, ETCBC tags it PreC) and **εἷς θεός** in apostolic restatement (1 Cor 8:6, Mark 12:29), and then forecloses any rival deity by stacking exclusivity particles, **עוד**, **בְּלֹאֵי**, **זוּלָּה**, **לֹא**, **אֶחָד** across Deut 4:35, Isa 44:6, and Isa 45:5. The numeral one alone is not decisive because **אֶחָד** also names composite unity (one flesh, Gen 2:24, one people, Gen 11:6), so the weight against three gods rests on the exclusivity formulas that deny any other God beside YHWH. Within that single confession Paul distributes **εἷς θεός ὁ πατήρ** and **εἷς κύριος Ἰησοῦς Χριστός**, placing Father and Son inside the one God rather than alongside it as a second deity. The pan-canonical lexical pattern denies a plurality of separate gods while preserving personal distinction, which is the substance of the proposition under test.

Scripture

Deut.6.4 · **for** · genre: law

Key terms. H3068 **יְהוָה**, H0430 **אֱלֹהִים**, H0259 **אֶחָד**

Force. The Shema couples the covenant name YHWH with the cardinal numeral **אֶחָד** in predicative position, asserting that YHWH our God is one. ETCBC tags the clause as quotative (Q) with **אֶחָד** as PreC, the predicate of the confession, and **יְהוָה** as Subj. The numeral is the ordinary cardinal one. By itself **אֶחָד** can frame composite unity (one flesh, Gen 2:24, one people, Gen 11:6, queried and confirmed), so the verse establishes singular count of the one God but leaves the foreclosure of rival gods to the exclusivity particles in the parallel texts.

Isa.45.5 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 **יְהוָה**, H0369 **אֵין**, H0589 **אֲנִי**, H2108 **זוּלָּה**, H3808 **לֹא**, H5750 **עוד**

Force. YHWH's first-person self-declaration stacks negation and exclusivity particles. **עוד** **יְהוָה אֲנִי** affirms I am YHWH and there is no other, then **זוּלָּתִי ... אֵין** excludes any besides me, with **לֹא** reinforcing the negation. ETCBC marks the negations as Nega and NCop and the exclusivity term as Modi or Adju, syntactically denying the existence of any other God. The combination of **אֵין** plus **עוד** plus **זוּלָּה** is the lexical engine that rules out a plurality of gods.

Isa.44.6 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H0369 אֲנִי, H0314 אַחֲרָי, H1107 בְּלַעַדִּי.

Force. Queried token set confirms אֲנִי (H0369), אַחֲרָי last (H0314), and בְּלַעַדִּי besides me (H1107). YHWH declares himself the first and the last and that besides him there is no god. בְּלַעַדִּי is a parallel exclusivity term to הֵלֵךְ (each rare, 16 and 13 occurrences) and both function the same way, denying any deity apart from YHWH. This adds a second independent exclusivity lexeme to the same pattern, strengthening the canonical denial of other gods.

1Cor.8.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G2316 θεός, G3962 πατήρ, G5547 Χριστός, G0235 ἀλλά

Force. Paul places εἷς θεός ὁ πατήρ and εἷς κύριος Ἰησοῦς Χριστός in a single contrast clause introduced by ἀλλ' ἡμῖν. The numeral εἷς (queried present in this verse) governs both θεός and κύριος in parallel without producing two gods, because the Father and Christ are distributed across the elements of the Shema (ὁ πατήρ aligns with θεός, ὁ κύριος Ἰησοῦς Χριστός aligns with κύριος). The prepositions ἐξ οὗ and δι' οὗ map creation to both, holding them within one source rather than tallying two deities.

Deut.4.35 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H0369 אֲנִי, H5750 עוֹד, H3045 יָדַע.

Force. Parallel monotheistic formula. Queried token set confirms אֲנִי (H0369) and עוֹד (H5750) in this verse. יָדַע הוּא הֵאלֹהִים אֲנִי עוֹד states that YHWH is the God, there is no other besides him. The same אֲנִי and עוֹד pair found in Isa 45:5 anchors a single canonical lexical pattern of exclusive deity in the Torah, linked by cross-reference to the Shema in the next chapter.

1Cor.8.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3762 οὐδεὶς, G2316 θεός, G1520 εἷς

Force. Immediate context to 1 Cor 8:6, with εἷς queried present here as well. Paul affirms οὐδεὶς θεός εἰ μὴ εἷς, no God except one. This sets the numeral one as the controlling count for the deity word θεός before he distributes Father and Son inside that one in verse 6, the Greek mirror of the Hebrew exclusivity formulas.

Mark.12.29 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2962 κύριος, G2316 θεός, G1520 εἷς

Force. Jesus cites the Shema in Greek, κύριος ὁ θεὸς ἡμῶν κύριος εἷς ἐστίν, with εἷς and θεός queried present. Jesus himself anchors the one-God confession with the same numeral εἷς used in 1 Cor 8:6, demonstrating canonical continuity of the lexical pattern from Torah to Gospels and confirming that the count of one is carried, not abandoned, in the New Testament.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Deut.6.4	Deut.4.35	tsk	1
Isa.45.5	Isa.45.14	tsk	1
Isa.45.5	Isa.22.21	tsk	1
1Cor.8.6	1Cor.8.4	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gen.2.24 · addressed

The same numeral **אֶחָד** used of God in Deut 6:4 names a composite unity here (man and wife become one flesh, **אֶחָד**, **בָּשָׂר אֶחָד**), queried and confirmed alongside Gen 11:6 (one people) and Ezek 37:17 (two sticks become one). This means the bare numeral does not by itself foreclose plurality, which is why the verdict rests on the exclusivity particles (**אֵין**, **זוּלָה**, **בְּלִעְדֵּי**, **עוֹד**) rather than on the count word alone. This is the genuine lexical seam both rival readings press.

Gen.1.26 · addressed

The first person plural cohortative **נַעֲשֶׂה** (let us make) appears with singular subject Elohim and produces a singular outcome in v.27 (**וַיִּבְרָא**, he created, singular). The plural verb form does not yield plural gods. The same pattern recurs in Gen 11:7 and Isa 6:8 without dissolving the canonical monotheism affirmed in Deut 6:4 and Isa 45:5.

Ps.82.1 · addressed

אֱלֹהִים in the assembly of **אֵל** is judicial language for human or angelic rulers (cf. the citation in John 10:34 explaining these are those to whom the word of God came). The lexeme **אֱלֹהִים** has broader semantic range than the count noun god in English and does not contradict the singular numeral **אֶחָד** applied to YHWH.

Matt.28.19 · addressed

The triadic baptismal formula uses singular **ὄνομα** (name, not names) governing three articulated genitives. The lexical singular of **ὄνομα** prevents reading three separate deities, while the three distinct articulated Persons prevent reduction to one Person. This matches the one essence with personal distinction grammar implied by 1 Cor 8:6.

John.10.30 · addressed

ἐγὼ καὶ ὁ πατήρ ἓν ἐσμεν uses the neuter **ἓν** (one thing) with plural verb **ἐσμεν** (we are). The neuter numeral signals unity of essence or action rather than collapse of Persons. This lexical choice corroborates rather than contradicts the divine unity affirmed in the Shema.

Concordance traversed

H0259, H0369, H3808, H2108, H1107, H5750, H3068, H0430, H0905, G1520, G2316, G3962, G5547, G2962, G3762, G0235, G1223, G1519, G1537

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Deut 6:4, Deut 4:35, Isa 44:6, and Isa 45:5 are Hebrew text with stable MT witness in WLC and ETCBC-BHSA, and the OT is not in ECM scope. 1 Cor 8:4 to 8:6 and Mark 12:29 have no significant variation affecting **εἷς θεός** or **εἷς κύριος** in the queried token set, and **not_in_ecm_scope** is true for this bundle.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. **covenantal_monotheism**, **shema_reformulation**

analogia scripturae invoked · **progressive revelation** factor

covenantal_monotheism: supports · Reads Deut 6:4 as a covenantal oath of exclusive allegiance to one YHWH, with prophetic restatements (Isa 44:6, Isa 45:5) and apostolic reformulation (1 Cor 8:6, Mark 12:29) preserving the count of one God across covenants. The exclusivity particles **אֵין**, **זוּלָה**, **בְּלִעְדֵּי**, **עוֹד** carry the denial of rival gods.

shema_reformulation: supports · Treats 1 Cor 8:6 as a christological expansion of Deut 6:4 where **κύριος** and **θεός** are split across Father and Son without multiplying the count, yielding divine unity with personal distinction inside the one-God confession.

tritheist_reading: complicates · Its strongest lexical case leans on the plural noun אֱלֹהִים, the plural cohortative וְעָשָׂה (Gen 1:26), and the distinct articulated Persons (ὁ πατήρ, ὁ κύριος Ἰησοῦς, the third in Matt 28:19) to argue for more than one divine being. The lexical data answers it directly. The exclusivity particles אֵין and וְאֵין and בְּלִעְדֵּי deny any God besides YHWH, the cohortative still yields a singular verb in Gen 1:27, and 1 Cor 8:6 holds Father and Son inside one εἷς θεός, so the words foreclose three separate gods.

strict_unitarian_reading: partially_complicates · Its strongest lexical case reads τῆς and εἷς θεός as numerically excluding any distinct person within the deity, treating Father alone as God. The lexical data tempers this by noting that 1 Cor 8:6 itself distributes εἷς across Father and Son in the same one-confession, Mark 12:29 in Jesus' own mouth keeps the count, and Matt 28:19 keeps singular ὄνομα over three Persons, so the count of one constrains the number of gods, not the recognition of distinct Persons.

The verdict turns on two lexical facts held together. First, the cardinal numeral one (τῆς, εἷς) is predicated of God, but that numeral alone also frames composite unity (Gen 2:24), so it is not decisive on its own. Second, the exclusivity particles (אֵין, וְאֵין, בְּלִעְדֵּי, לֹא, זָלָה) deny any other God, which is what forecloses tritheism. Personal distinction is signaled by separate articulated nouns (ὁ πατήρ, ὁ κύριος Ἰησοῦς) and the triadic formula governed by singular ὄνομα.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The three Persons are one God, not three separate gods; within the one divine being the Father, Son, and Spirit are distinct yet are not three deities.

The proposition is a denial stem that encodes its own conclusion (tritheism is false). The phrase three Persons and one divine essence is post-biblical creedal vocabulary (ousia, hypostasis, persona) not found verbatim in the canon. The lexical evidence supports the substance of the claim using biblical categories. The numeral τῆς and εἷς applied to God, the exclusivity particles denying any other God, and distinct articulated Father, Son, and Spirit held inside the one confession. The verdict was derived on the original stem. The neutralized form restates the same claim without the technical Trinitarian vocabulary so a reader outside that tradition can still see what is affirmed and what is denied.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.6.4
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.45.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.44.6
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Isa.45.5
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0259
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0369
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2108
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1107
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1520
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2316
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.8.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.12.29
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.8.6
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Deut.6.4
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Isa.45.5
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